communication and release, and in turn the fun and enjoyment sends me back into the game with a refreshed view on it.

In our third episode, a Bristolian called Matt Horan phones in. He invented a roll-up vending machine shoe company called Rollasole, he explains. He doesn't have any interest in cricket, having just heard of the show as a Maccabees fan, but thinks he has a cricketing familial tie we might be interested in. He is distantly related to, he claims, Sachin Tendulkar. As we try to explain that Tendulkar might be the greatest cricketer who ever lived, the show then trips itself into a left-field, on the fly comedy exploring whether Matt is indeed related to Sachin Tendulkar. We lovingly call him Mattchin Tendulkar, and within a few episodes, he's a cricketing cult hero. He's not just a roll-up shoe salesman, it turns out, but with every passing week has more and more questions about cricket and ideas about how it might be made more interesting to the wider public. The four of us and Sharky begin a friendship, playing out in recorded episodes every week that accidentally explain cricket from every side – from total beginner to musician to broadcaster to cricketer – and before we know it, we will be recording every week together for the next seven years.

Some years later, Mattchin will pose an absurd theoretical question to me, asking if a wizard came up to me and offered me another ten years of my career, but the cost was I would always have a frog chasing me that would kill me if I touched it, would I take it? It prompts people to turn up to Tests wearing wizard and frog costumes, pretending to chase me around. People shout 'go well' at me, a *Tailenders* code for being a listener, to which you have to reply 'cheers', as a nod to the stereotypical sports interview ending. And every week, listeners around the world share their deepest cricket humiliations, hoping to be alleviated of their pain by having me read it out as Felix plays sad guitar music behind it. Before we know it, we are going on tour, with live bands, playing the London Palladium and the Apollo, and I'm dressing up as alter ego 'Timmy Banderson', who plays short-form franchise cricket and is under no scrutiny about when he might retire. For some reason Timmy is American too and skateboards on to the stage.

From time to time, my teammates come on the show. When they do, they stare at me, quite confused by what they see, as if they're watching someone completely different. For all of us, it doesn't consciously land, but